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POLICY BRIEF

Three Horizons in Public Policy

What the method illuminates, what the book does not yet prove, and how Brazil could test it in the energy transition

3	35 TO 85 YEARS	~200
CRITIQUES OF THE METHOD LISTED BY THE AUTHORS THEMSELVES	FOR A POLICY IDEA TO MOVE FROM FRAMING TO RESOLUTION	INITIATIVES IN THE 1ST CYCLE (2026-2029) OF BRAZIL'S NATIONAL ENERGY TRANSITION PLAN

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Executive Summary

The Three Horizons Approach (edited by Gale, Curry, Robinson and Hadidimoud; Palgrave Macmillan, 2026, open access) gathers in one volume a method for mapping a transition between the dominant system (Horizon 1), the still-marginal future (Horizon 3) and the turbulent interval between them (Horizon 2). For public policy, the method offers a language for treating transition as a conflict of values, not as a stage in a schedule. The book, however, reports practice and does not measure effect, and Brazil does not appear in it.

01 The method treats transition as a dispute

Horizon 2 is not a system: it is the space where the current arrangement and the emerging future collide. This shifts the focus from "what is the plan" to "who loses, who gains and which values are in conflict".

02 The most useful concept is the capture test

The evaluation chapter separates "H2 plus" innovations, which accelerate change, from "H2 minus" innovations, which are promoted or absorbed by those who already dominate the system in order to preserve their interests. Every administration knows the pilot that becomes a showcase.

03 The evidence is reported practice, not effect

The authors themselves acknowledge that the literature on the method is largely explanation and advocacy, with few critical voices. In the chapters read, there is no evaluation of the method's effect on decisions or policy outcomes.

04 Brazil already has a place to test it: the energy transition

Brazil's National Energy Transition Plan (Plante) has a 30-year horizon, four-year cycles and a review at the end of each one. Together with the monitoring and evaluation provided for in the 2024-2027 Multiyear Plan (PPA), it is the natural ground for a first test, with one concrete case: the Jorge Lacerda Thermoelectric Complex (Law 14,299/2022).

HIGHLIGHT The decisive question is not whether the State can imagine Horizon 3. It is who, inside it, has the mandate to say that an innovation is reinforcing what should change.

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In numbers

Indicator	Result	Reading
Pages in the book (PDF file)	463	Four parts and a glossary, according to the book itself
Critiques of the method listed by the authors	3	Single future, utopia and S-curve
Patterns of system change (Fazey and Leicester, cited in the book)	4	The smooth, S-curve transition is described as rare
Time for a policy idea to move from "framing" to "resolution" (Molitor, cited in the book)	35 to 85 years	A maturation horizon far longer than the cycle of a plan
Ideas extracted from survey responses in the evaluation initiative	more than 1,300	Idea fragments (not people), separated with the help of a language model and regrouped through weekly human review over one year
Mentions of Brazil in the text of the book	0	Text search of the full file
Horizon of the National Energy Transition Plan (Plante)	30 years	Four-year cycles; 1st cycle 2026-2029; next, 2030-2033
Initiatives in the Plante Action Booklet	about 200	In 15 action blocks and three pillars
Resources of the Energy Transition Program in the draft PPA (INESC, 2023)	R$ 937.8 million	About 0.2% of the oil and gas program (R$ 478.9 billion), all in non-budgetary resources

1. The public problem

Transition policies (energy, AI, climate, health) outlast terms of office and oppose values, not only interests. Plans treat change as a sequence of deliverables. When the opposition between the current system and the desired system is not named, it reappears in implementation as delay, capture or reversal.

The Three Horizons method proposes naming that conflict first. Horizon 1 is the dominant system, which loses fit with its environment over time. Horizon 3 gathers proposals that are marginal today and may replace it. Horizon 2 is the interval in which the two logics compete, and it is where public policy actually operates.

Evidence. The book presents Horizon 2 as a "typically unstable" transition space marked by clashes of values (chapter 1, PDF p. 34), and describes four patterns of system change, of which the smooth transition is the rare one (PDF p. 43).

Inference. For the manager, the value lies less in the diagram and more in the obligation to make explicit who loses under each path.

Recommendation. Use the method for long transition themes with declared value conflicts, not for routine decisions.

2. Method and limitations

This brief reads the book as evidence about the method, not as proof that it works. The reading covered in full the history and theory chapter and the chapter on evaluation in a world of polycrisis, plus excerpts and abstracts of the chapters on artificial intelligence, the energy transition in Alberta and Chilean Patagonia. The rest of the volume was consulted by text search.

- The book gathers practitioners' accounts, generally by the authors of the initiatives themselves, which limits independent assessment of results.
- In one of the studies described, participants in the six workshops were self-selected (109 people). Another chapter acknowledges that application requires skilled facilitation, time and follow-up, at the risk of results remaining merely aspirational.
- The chapter on artificial intelligence is a retrospective of the author's own 2018 thesis: it serves as illustration, not as an independent test of the forecast.
- The Brazilian analysis uses the text of the legal norms and the official description of Plante, not an evaluation of the performance of the PPA, the CMAP or the Plan. The final status of Plante (approval by the National Energy Policy Council, CNPE) is yet to be confirmed.

DEFINITION Horizon 2 plus and minus: "H2 plus" innovations seek to accelerate the transition to Horizon 3; "H2 minus" innovations are promoted or absorbed by Horizon 1 actors to preserve their interests and may delay change (evaluation chapter, PDF p. 395).

3. Case Study

The Three Horizons for Evaluation Initiative (International Evaluation Academy)

The International Evaluation Academy ran, over one year, an exercise to reimagine the field of evaluation for a world of polycrisis. The design combined a targeted global survey, the support of a language model to separate the responses into more than 1,300 ideas, and weekly human review by a core team of eight people, supported by 14 collaborators. The authors added to the method the H2 plus and H2 minus distinction to separate transformative initiatives from reinforcement of the status quo.

The starting point is a diagnosis that matters to any policy evaluation system: dominant practice is largely retrospective, short-term and driven by accountability to funders, not by learning.

Element	What the chapter reports	Why it matters for Brazil
Diagnosis	Evaluation often only retrospective and conservative	Same issue as ex post policy evaluation
Design	Survey, language model as support, human decision	Use of AI without delegating judgment
Result	Maps of the horizons and four key pathways for action	A product usable as a public reference
Limit	Account by the organizers themselves	No independent evaluation of the effect

ALERT The case is described by the organizers themselves. It shows the feasibility of the design, not proven effectiveness of the method.

4. A Brazilian perspective: the energy transition

The energy transition brings together the conditions in which the method is most useful: change over decades, conflicting regional and industrial interests, and long-term public instruments already in place. Three of them fit together.

Instrument	What it provides	Source
National Energy Transition Plan (Plante)	Interministerial plan for 30 years, in four-year cycles with a review at the end of each; 1st cycle 2026-2029; three pillars, 15 blocks and about 200 initiatives; public consultation opened on 04/29/2026 for 45 days	Agência Gov (Ministry of Mines and Energy)
Law 14,802/2024 (PPA 2024-2027)	Annual monitoring report by September 30 (art. 16); evaluation by the CMAP (art. 17, § 1); civil society observatory, by act of the Executive (art. 22, § 3)	Planalto
Law 14,299/2022 (Just Energy Transition)	Program to prepare the coal region of Santa Catarina for the probable end of coal-fired generation by 2040 (art. 4, § 1); transition plan within 12 months (art. 4, § 3); 15-year extension of the Jorge Lacerda Thermoelectric Complex authorization from 01/01/2025 (art. 6)	Planalto

The test case: Jorge Lacerda Complex

Evidence. Law 14,299/2022 combines two logics: it requires a 15-year extension of the thermoelectric complex's authorization and creates the program that is to prepare the region for the probable end of coal-fired generation by 2040, with a plan of actions, responsible parties, deadlines and funding sources.

Inference. In the book's vocabulary, the extension resembles the "capture and extension" pattern, in which actors of the current system extend their horizon (chapter 1, PDF p. 43), alongside a seed of Horizon 3. Whether each action in the plan reduces dependence on coal (H2 plus) or prolongs it (H2 minus) is an empirical question the exercise would answer.

To be checked. Whether the Just Transition Plan has been established and which actions, deadlines and funding sources it contains. The status of the program's Council and of a direct unconstitutionality action against the law was not confirmed in the sources consulted.

What the book does not resolve for Brazil

- The book does not mention Brazil, and the countries and cases in the chapters read are others (United Kingdom, Canada, South Africa, Chile).
- In the chapters read, there is no mechanism linking workshop results to budgets, legal mandates or external oversight. The only mention of corruption in the text is indirect, to the use of another method in Cyprus (PDF p. 69).
- The method assumes a skilled facilitator and time for participation, conditions that are unequal across bodies and levels of government.
- According to INESC's technical note (September 2023, on the draft 2024-2027 PPA), the Energy Transition Program (3107) provides R$ 937.8 million over four years, all in non-budgetary resources (unspecified tax subsidies), about 0.2% of the resources of the Oil, Natural Gas, Derivatives and Biofuels Program (3103), which has R$ 478.9 billion and whose specific objectives, according to the note, concern the expansion of fossil fuels. The values in the final text of the PPA are yet to be checked. The asymmetry is the kind of data a horizon map would make visible.

5. Recommendations

01 Map the horizons of Plante's first cycle (2026-2029)

Classify the roughly 200 initiatives in the Action Booklet as H1 plus (keep), H2 plus (accelerates change) and H2 minus (reinforces the current system), with criteria published before the classification. **Actor:** the Ministry of Mines and Energy, which coordinates Plante, with the technical chambers of the National Energy Transition Forum. **Condition:** transparent selection of participants and a record of who dissented. **Milestone:** before the review of the 2030-2033 cycle. **Risk of inaction:** the cycle is reviewed without knowing which initiatives changed the system.

02 Make Jorge Lacerda the test case for H2 plus and H2 minus

Establish whether the Just Transition Plan under art. 4, § 3 of Law 14,299/2022 has been set up and, for each action, record whether it reduces or prolongs dependence on coal. **Actor:** the Council of the Just Energy Transition program (coordinated by the Civil House), with the Ministry of Mines and Energy. **Condition:** publication of the plan, of the reserve-energy contracts and of employment and income indicators for the region. **Risk of inaction:** the extension runs its term and the transition remains only declared in law.

03 Include a commitments table in the PPA annual monitoring report

Build a table comparing the commitments, indicators and resources of the Energy Transition Program (3107) with those of the Oil, Natural Gas, Derivatives and Biofuels Program (3103), with responsible parties and deadlines. **Actor:** the central planning and budget body, with the Ministry of Mines and Energy. **Condition:** values checked against the current PPA and the federal budget system (SIOP), and the table included in the report the Executive sends to Congress by September 30 (art. 16 of Law 14,802/2024). **Risk of inaction:** the horizon map stays aspirational, with no budgetary consequence.

04 Publicly record value conflicts by action block

In the Forum's technical chambers, record and publish, by block, the central conflicts (for example, regional employment and decarbonization) and each group's position. **Actor:** the Ministry of Mines and Energy, with the observatory under art. 22, § 3 of Law 14,802/2024, if the Executive regulates it. **Condition:** a record with the name of the group and its justification. **Risk of inaction:** consultation becomes validation and the conflicts reappear in implementation.

05 Evaluate the method at the cycle review

Compare, at the 2030 review, the decisions of blocks that went through the exercise with those that did not. **Actor:** the CMAP, with universities. **Condition:** a comparative design defined in 2026-2027, before execution. **Risk of inaction:** repeating the pattern of the book, which describes the method without measuring its effect.

6. Decision matrix

Measure	Instrument	Responsible	Priority
01 Map horizons of the 1st cycle	Plante Action Booklet (2026-2029)	Ministry of Mines and Energy and the National Energy Transition Forum	High
02 Jorge Lacerda test case	Law 14,299/2022, arts. 4 and 6	Program Council (Civil House) and the Ministry	High
03 Comparative table of programs 3107 and 3103	PPA annual report (by 09/30)	Central planning body and the Ministry	High
04 Record of conflicts	Forum technical chambers; PPA observatory	Ministry of Mines and Energy	Medium
05 Comparative evaluation of the method	Decree 11,558/2023 (CMAP)	CMAP and universities	Medium

Conclusion

The Three Horizons offer the public sector a useful question: what, in the current system, needs to change, and who has an interest in it not changing. The book shows that the question circulates in many contexts, but not that the answer alters decisions. Brazil's energy transition has a 30-year plan in four-year cycles, annual monitoring provided for by law, and a concrete case, the coal of Santa Catarina, in which extension and transition live in the same legal text. What remains to be seen is whether a horizons exercise can, in the first cycle, separate what changes the system from what prolongs it.

Notes, sources and credits

1. Gale, T., Curry, A., Robinson, S., Hadidimoud, S. (eds.). *The Three Horizons Approach: Innovation Tools for Systems Transformation and Sustainable Futures*. Palgrave Macmillan, 2026. Open access (CC BY-NC-ND 4.0). DOI: https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-032-19004-8. Page numbers refer to the PDF file.

2. Curry, A. et al. Chapter 1, "Locating Three Horizons: The History and Theory of the Method" (PDF p. 32-48): Horizon 2, critiques of the method, patterns of system change, Molitor.

3. Ofir, Z., Kendrick, I., Goldman, I. Chapter "Three Horizons and the Reimagining of Evaluation for a World in Polycrisis" (PDF p. 391-410): H2 plus and H2 minus, evaluation initiative, use of AI.

4. McGlade, C. Chapter "Three Horizons and the Future of Artificial Intelligence (AI)" (PDF p. 95-107).

5. Brazil. Law 14,802 of January 10, 2024 (PPA 2024-2027): https://www.planalto.gov.br/ccivil_03/_ato2023-2026/2024/lei/L14802.htm

6. Brazil. Decree 11,558 of June 13, 2023 (CMAP): https://www.planalto.gov.br/ccivil_03/_ato2023-2026/2023/decreto/D11558.htm

7. Agência Gov / Ministry of Mines and Energy. "MME lança consulta pública do Plano Nacional de Transição Energética", April 2026: https://agenciagov.ebc.com.br/noticias/202604/mme-lanca-consulta-publica-do-plano-nacional-de-transicao-energetica

8. Brazil. Law 14,299 of January 5, 2022 (Just Energy Transition Program): https://www.planalto.gov.br/ccivil_03/_ato2019-2022/2022/lei/L14299.htm

9. INESC. Technical note "Transição energética: ausência de recursos no orçamento federal", September 2023: https://inesc.org.br/wp-content/uploads/2023/09/nt-ploa_ppa-energia-inesc.pdf (civil society organization; values from the draft PPA, to be checked against the final text and SIOP).